

BEFORE

The period of Greek history leading up to the Archaic period was preceded by the rich civilization of Mycenae and a period known as the “Dark Age” of Greece.

EARLY CIVILIZATION

Artifacts from Mycenae, Greece, are evidence of a rich Mediterranean civilization that existed before the rise of the city-states. The Mycenaean culture peaked in the 2nd millennium BCE.

THE “DARK AGE”

Between 1100 and 750 BCE, ancient Greece was in a “dark age” about which little is known. All of the future city-states were probably clusters of villages at this time.

EARLY ARCHAIC PERIOD

At the start of the Archaic Period (c. 750–480 BCE), increasing Mediterranean populations fueled the rise of cities such as Athens, Sparta, Thebes, and Corinth.

THE MAKING OF ATHENS

By the 7th century BCE, Athens was on the rise as a leading city-state. Central

to its identity was its legal system. Around 621 BCE, Athenian magistrate Draco laid down a series of strict laws—probably the city’s first significant legal code.

Later, the Athenian statesman, Solon (c. 630–560 BCE), brought in laws that helped protect the rights of “ordinary” people.



SOLON

INVENTION

GEOMETRY

The period of the city-states saw philosophers and scholars such as Thales of Miletus bringing together mathematical principles from ancient Mesopotamia and Egypt to invent geometry, (*geo* meaning “Earth” and *metron* “measure” in Greek). The defining work on geometry was written by Euclid, a mathematician from Egypt, born c. 300 BCE, author of a treatise on geometry, the *Elements*.

11TH CENTURY RELIEF OF EUCLID



Theater at Epidauros

This vast 4th-century theater was built at Epidauros, a city-state in the Peloponnese. The best-preserved theater to survive from ancient Greece, it seated around 12,000 people and has exceptional acoustics. The theater of the ancient Greeks influenced the development of both drama and theater design.



The leading centers of civilization in 6th- and 5th-century BCE Greece included Athens, Sparta, and Corinth. These communities are now referred to as city-states. Many of the architectural features of these city-states are shared by cities today. Typically, they were walled, with a central citadel or *acropolis* (characteristically a place of refuge housing a temple on raised ground), a main marketplace (*agora*), a sporting and socializing center

City-states of the Greek model came to exist throughout the Aegean and its islands, in western Asia Minor (Ephesus), Sicily (Syracuse), southern Italy (Tarentum), Africa (notably Cyrene, in Libya), and in France (Marseilles).

Athens

A major figure in the story of the city-state was the Athenian magistrate Cleisthenes (c. 570–508 BCE) who instituted major reforms in the system

The Greek City-states

The rise of the *polis*—city-state—in ancient Greece was a major development in world politics. Great states such as Athens, Sparta, and Corinth provided a variety of models for ruling through a system of law, with Athens in particular paving the way to a groundbreaking idea: democratic government.

(*gymnasium*), and one or more temples. Although termed “cities,” population levels were low, and Sparta probably remained principally a cluster of villages. What was important, and central to the city-state concept, was that the inhabitants identified with their state first. So being a “citizen” of Sparta—a Spartan—was more important than being Greek. Beyond this, the city-states often varied greatly in character, each shifting through various types of government at different times. These included monarchy, tyranny (where there was one strong leader, not necessarily an unpopular one as implied by the modern use of the word), oligarchy (rule by a small group of people, typically nobles) and democracy. The eligible male citizens participated to varying degrees in many of these forms. This participation and idea of self-rule became one of the key characteristics of many of the city-states that came later.

CITY-STATE Often translated as *polis* in the context of ancient Greece. These states were independent, self-contained entities bound by the rule of law. They reached their height during the classical period, which lasted from c.480–323 BCE.

of rule. He changed the Athenian tribal system and permanently altered Athens’ political structure. He divided citizens into ten “tribes” (*phylae*), named after heroes. Attica (the area around Athens) was divided into three areas—coast, highlands, and city—and the tribes were made up of citizens from each of these areas and subdivided further into *demes*, the

smallest voting districts of the polis. The 5th-century statesman Pericles (c. 495–429 BCE) moved Athens farther toward a new kind of democracy (see



The acroterion was a decorative feature above the pediment.

The eastern pediment was filled with sculptures depicting Greek mythology.

Sanctuary of Athena

This is one of several buildings clustered around the oracle at Delphi, a sacred site close to the Gulf of Corinth.

Temple of Apollo

From about 650 to 550 BCE, Corinth experienced a golden era. With colonies in the Adriatic and Macedonia, its command of several important harbors made it an important seafaring and trading center.



Parthenon treasure

This exquisite sculpture from the Parthenon in Athens is widely believed to have come from the workshop of Phidias, the most famous sculptor in ancient Greece.